

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Cross-Cultural Leadership English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For managers, cross-border teams, HR partners, and meeting facilitators.

Ask about individual preferences and team norms. Nationality, accent, silence, or directness does not tell you what a person believes or how they will behave.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Check meaning before assuming agreement

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Challenge ideas respectfully

State a concern respectfully and propose a practical route forward.

03 Make authority and participation clear

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

04 Negotiate realistic commitments

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

05 Include every voice in a meeting

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

06 Give specific, useful feedback

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

07 Coordinate across offices

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

08 Repair misunderstandings and build trust

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Check meaning before assuming agreement

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

In a branch meeting, two colleagues say the launch plan is "fine." One later emails a concern about staffing. The manager had recorded agreement.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: assumption, clarification, expectation.

Model response

When you said the plan was fine, did you mean you supported the date or still had concerns? Let's check each person's view before I record a decision.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. A - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Reopening the launch agreement - The branch manager follows up on the lesson's launch meeting after receiving a staffing concern.
2. Available does not mean assigned - A separate fictional branch case: a training coordinator has two free hours Thursday, but no assignment has been agreed.
3. Whose end of day? - A separate fictional handoff connects offices using Eastern and Pacific time. A request says only 'end of day.'

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A calendar acceptance with a condition

In a fictional branch, an analyst accepted a meeting invitation but added a note that they could attend only the first fifteen minutes. The manager has scheduled that analyst's item last in a thirty-minute meeting.

Role A: You are the analyst. Clarify what your acceptance meant and request a workable speaking slot.

Role B: You are the manager. Check the time limit and discuss moving the item without assuming the agenda change is already agreed.

Possible opening: I accepted the invitation for the first fifteen minutes, but my item is currently last.

Success checks

- Distinguish accepting an invitation from full-meeting availability.
- State the fifteen-minute limit accurately.
- Agree a feasible speaking slot or an explicit follow-up.

Add a complication: Another participant needs the first ten minutes for a separate decision; negotiate the remaining time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Challenge ideas respectfully

State a concern respectfully and propose a practical route forward.

CASE

A colleague says, "This proposal makes no sense." The group goes quiet. You want to hear the concern without accepting personal attacks.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal without pretending agreement. Name the specific problem and its implication, then ask a focused question or propose a next step. Be direct when a safety or ethical boundary requires it.

Vocabulary to check: objection, behavioral example, boundary.

Model response

I'd like to understand the objection. Which assumption do you disagree with? Please focus on the proposal so we can examine it together.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence identifies a testable concern about the proposal. It leaves room for a constructive response.

Second-round challenge

The other person repeats the request more firmly. Restate the specific concern calmly and explain the appropriate next route.

Language-check answers

1. C - The proposal assumes the review is complete; the record shows it is still open. It connects the concern to a specific assumption and record.
2. B - Could we resolve the missing approval before confirming the plan? It names the unresolved condition and a practical next step.

05 • Conversations

1. Turning a dismissal into an objection - A separate fictional branch proposal allocates one employee to two simultaneous reception desks. The facilitator addresses a department lead's broad dismissal of that proposal.
2. Protecting a review step - A separate fictional branch plans a customer mailing. The proposed schedule omits a review step agreed by this project team.

3. Responding to an interruption complaint - A separate fictional branch plan schedules training Monday, but its required practice accounts will be available Wednesday. The project lead interrupted the scheduler twice while this dependency was being explained.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A scorecard is called pointless

A fictional branch uses a proposed weekly scorecard with six measures. A supervisor calls it pointless because two measures duplicate an existing report. No one has assessed the other four.

Role A: You facilitate the discussion. Ask for a specific objection and prevent a blanket dismissal.

Role B: You are the supervisor. Explain the duplication and propose reviewing the remaining four measures.

Possible opening: Could we separate the two duplicated measures from the four we haven't assessed?

Success checks

- Focus on the two observed duplications.
- Respectfully separate work criticism from a personal judgment.
- Agree how to assess the remaining measures without assuming their value.

Add a complication: The sponsor interprets criticism of the scorecard as criticism of its author.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Make authority and participation clear

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

CASE

Your team wants more direction, but the manager has been answering every question. A new hire has stopped offering ideas.

Teach this move

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: decision rights, role clarity, facilitation.

Model response

I'll make the final decision on staffing. Before that, I want each of you to suggest one option. You can speak now or send a note after the meeting.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Second-round challenge

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Language-check answers

1. B - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. A - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

05 • Conversations

1. Direction without answering every question - The manager in the lesson invites the new hire to discuss participation before the next team meeting.
2. A recommendation is not purchasing approval - A separate fictional branch: a facilities group may recommend furniture, while the branch director holds purchase approval.

3. Who owns the shift decision? - A separate fictional branch: two supervisors each believe the other approves a proposed shift swap; no authority has been confirmed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The acting chair's limits

In a fictional branch, a coordinator is chairing a meeting while the director is absent. The group can recommend a new visitor process, but only the director can approve it. Reception has not spoken.

Role A: You are the acting chair. Invite reception's input and close with a recommendation, not an approval.

Role B: You represent reception. Ask how visitor delays will be considered and who makes the final decision.

Possible opening: Before we make a recommendation, I'd like reception's view on the proposed visitor process.

Success checks

- Invite the missing operational perspective.
- Identify the director's approval role.
- Close with a recommendation and any unresolved question clearly separated.

Add a complication: A participant asks you to announce immediate implementation because everyone present seems satisfied.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Negotiate realistic commitments

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

Headquarters asks for a report on Friday. The local team can produce verified figures on Monday or a clearly labeled estimate on Friday.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: commitment, tradeoff, deadline.

Model response

We can send an estimate on Friday or verified figures on Monday. Which would meet your need? If we send the estimate, I'll label the figures as provisional.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

05 • Conversations

1. Friday estimate or Monday verification - Headquarters and the branch negotiate the two reporting options supplied in the lesson.
2. A smaller orientation session - A separate fictional branch has one trainer available for a two-hour session; the requested full orientation takes four hours.

3. The visit agenda exceeds the available hour - A separate fictional branch visit has a confirmed one-hour discussion slot and six requested topics, each allocated fifteen minutes.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Coverage for a demonstration

A fictional branch can spare one specialist for either a thirty-minute customer demonstration or a thirty-minute internal rehearsal this afternoon, not both. A second specialist's availability is unknown.

Role A: You coordinate staffing. Offer the two feasible choices without promising extra coverage.

Role B: You organize the demonstration. Choose a priority and state what would need separate approval or scheduling.

Possible opening: We have one thirty-minute specialist slot, so we need to choose its purpose.

Success checks

- State the capacity limit and both options.
- Keep the second specialist's availability unknown.
- Agree one commitment and identify the deferred activity.

Add a complication: The organizer asks you to promise the second specialist before their availability is checked.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Include every voice in a meeting

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

CASE

Three people speak at once during a hybrid meeting. A remote colleague's question is missed, and nobody knows who can approve the plan.

Teach this move

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: facilitation, meeting minutes, action item.

Model response

Let's hear Morgan's question first. Then we'll take one comment at a time. Before we finish, can we confirm who approves the plan and when?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Second-round challenge

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Language-check answers

1. C - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. B - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

05 • Conversations

1. Recovering the remote question - The lesson's hybrid meeting has overlapping speakers, a missed remote question, and unclear approval responsibility.
2. A chat comment omitted from the summary - A separate fictional meeting: a warehouse representative posted a delivery-access concern in chat, but the chair's summary omitted it.

3. The timer and the unanswered question - A separate fictional planning call has three minutes remaining; a service coordinator has been waiting to ask about staffing.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Rejoining after a lost connection

A fictional procurement meeting discussed two suppliers while the technical lead lost connection. No supplier was approved, but the returning lead heard only 'we are moving forward.'

Role A: You chair the meeting. Restore the missing context and invite the technical concern before closing.

Role B: You are the technical lead. Ask what was discussed, what was decided, and how your compatibility concern will be handled.

Possible opening: Before we close, let me separate the supplier discussion from any approval you may have missed.

Success checks

- State that neither supplier was approved.
- Give the returning participant a protected speaking turn.
- Agree an owner for the compatibility question and an accurate closing summary.

Add a complication: Only two minutes remain, and another participant wants to end without hearing the concern.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Give specific, useful feedback

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

CASE

Two weekly reports arrived a day after the agreed deadline. The manager does not know the reason. Other teams depend on the figures.

Teach this move

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Vocabulary to check: feedback, expectation, support plan.

Model response

The last two reports arrived on Tuesday instead of Monday. That delayed our review. What is getting in the way, and what support would help you meet Monday's deadline?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision identifies observable work. 'Always' and a personality judgment make the feedback harder to verify or act on.

Second-round challenge

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Language-check answers

1. B - The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date. The recipient can check the specific examples and discuss how to improve them.
2. A - What is making this part of the task difficult? An open question may reveal a barrier the speaker has not considered.

05 • Conversations

1. Two late reports without a guessed cause - The lesson's manager gives feedback on two reports that arrived one day late; the cause remains unknown.
2. An update without a next action - A separate fictional branch: two project updates listed problems but omitted the requested next-action section.

3. Feedback on rushed explanations - A separate fictional onboarding session: a trainer changed screens twice before a new coordinator finished a question.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Customer handoffs without contact names

In a fictional branch, the last two customer handoffs omitted a contact name. The receiving team had to ask who to call. The reason for the omissions is unknown.

Role A: You supervise the handoff process. Give specific feedback and ask about the obstacle.

Role B: You prepared the handoffs. Discuss how to flag an unknown contact rather than filling in a guess.

Possible opening: The last two handoffs had no contact name, so the receiving team had to ask who to call.

Success checks

- Describe the two omissions and their observed effect.
- Ask about the cause without assigning a personality label.
- Agree a support step and a way to identify genuinely unknown contacts.

Add a complication: The supervisor initially suggests another reminder before understanding the obstacle; revisit that assumption.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Coordinate across offices

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

Headquarters requests daily detail. The branch says the reporting takes an hour each day. Neither side has explained what information it actually needs.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: operating agreement, workload, stakeholder engagement.

Model response

Headquarters needs early notice of delays; the branch needs time to deliver the work. Could we try a short daily exception report and review the arrangement in two weeks?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. C - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Detail versus decision information - Headquarters and the branch discuss the lesson's daily report, which takes the branch an hour to prepare.
2. An exception report is not a complete log - A separate fictional branch proposes reporting delayed deliveries only; headquarters currently receives a log of every delivery.

3. Consulted is not copied - A separate fictional branch project copies the service desk on announcements but has not asked about implementation workload.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Receipt versus resolution

In a fictional cross-office support arrangement, headquarters wants branches to acknowledge requests within one working day. A branch interprets that as a promise to resolve every request in one day. No resolution deadline has been agreed.

Role A: You coordinate headquarters support. Explain acknowledgment and resolution in plain English.

Role B: You manage a branch. Paraphrase the difference and ask how unresolved requests should be updated.

Possible opening: Acknowledging a request means confirming receipt; it does not mean the work is finished.

Success checks

- Preserve the one-working-day acknowledgment expectation.
- State that resolution timing remains unagreed.
- Propose discussing update expectations as part of the operating agreement.

Add a complication: A sponsor wants to describe the arrangement as a one-day service guarantee.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Repair misunderstandings and build trust

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

You interrupted a colleague twice while they explained a concern. They later say they felt dismissed. The concern is still unresolved.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: acknowledgment, accountability, trust.

Model response

I interrupted you and missed part of your concern. I'm sorry. Could we return to it now? At our next meeting, I'll let you finish before I respond.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. C - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. B - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 • Conversations

1. Returning to the concern you interrupted - The lesson's manager speaks with the colleague who felt dismissed after two interruptions.
2. Correcting an inaccurate endorsement - A separate fictional branch: a director told headquarters that a planner endorsed an option when the planner had only requested a cost review.

3. An apology without a cultural explanation - A separate fictional branch: a coordinator joked about a colleague's presentation style, and the colleague said the comment was unwelcome.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Leaving a contributor out of the credit

In a fictional branch, a manager's verbal project summary credited one analyst but omitted a coordinator who organized the interviews. The coordinator has raised the omission privately. The summary can be corrected at the next team meeting.

Role A: You are the manager. Acknowledge the omission and offer a precise correction without claiming intent you cannot establish.

Role B: You are the coordinator. Explain what contribution should be recognized and request accurate wording.

Possible opening: I left your interview coordination out of the summary, and I want to correct that accurately.

Success checks

- Name the omitted contribution without exaggerating it.
- Agree a concrete correction at the next meeting.
- Avoid demanding forgiveness or promising perfect future behavior.

Add a complication: The manager is tempted to promise that no contribution will ever be missed again.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Ask about individual preferences and team norms. Nationality, accent, silence, or directness does not tell you what a person believes or how they will behave.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.